

Colorado Field Ornithologists Sight Record Form

2000-65

(This is a two-page report. Please print or type. Attach photographs and additional pages if necessary.)

Each table cell will automatically enlarge as you type!

Red 2/5/01 upl
(3 photos)

CFO-RC FILE X:

RESULTS:

Species:(Common Name) BLACK-LEGGED KITTIWAKE		(Scientific Name) <i>Thryothorus ludovicianus</i>
Date(s) of occurrence: 27 October 2000		
Number of birds seen: 1	Sex: Unknown	Plumage: AHY
Exact location: Marina at South Shore of Chatfield Reservoir		
County: Douglas	Nearest town: Littleton	Elevation: 5432 msl
Length of observation: Approximately a 10-minute segment, off and on.	Time(s) of observation: Approximately 3:30 PM MST	
Other observers who saw the bird(s) with you:		
Other Observers who independently saw the bird(s): Joey Kellner		
Light Conditions (quality; direction relative to bird(s); position: Mostly Overcast		
Optical equipment used: Leica 20-60 Zoom Spotting Scope, 8 X 40 Swift Ultra-lite Binoculars		
Distance from bird(s) (estimated unless otherwise noted): Varied between 50 and 100 meters		
Was bird(s) photographed? Yes (video)	If so, have you submitted photos? Yes (clips from video)	
Who took the photographs? Semo		

Describe the general and specific habitat in which the bird(s) occurred: Open water and tires of docks

Describe the bird's behavior (flying, feeding, habits, behaviors used in identifying the Species or in supporting the identification): Varied between swimming, flying, and standing on tires.

Describe the bird in detail. This is the most important part of this report. Include the overall size and shape and how you placed the bird in the general group that you did. Give complete details of plumage, including head, throat, undersides, nape, back, wings and tail. Give particular emphasis to marks you used to identify the bird(s). Describe other important details, such as color and shape of bill, legs, eye, (etc.) that were important in making the identification. (Fill out this portion even if photographs are submitted; you may attach additional sheets, drawings, field sketches or copy field notes):

I arrived at the Chatfield State Park marina, located on the south shore of Chatfield Reservoir, Douglas County and began observing the gulls at the northern end of the marina. After searching for perhaps 20 minutes, with no success of finding the kittiwake (only Ring-billed Gulls observed), I drove to the boat landing at the southern end of the marina. A few other birders were present at this locale and notified me that the kittiwake was indeed present. After a few moments, we observed the bird swimming in the small bay that incorporated the marina.

Noticed was a small to medium-sized gull that was seemingly slightly smaller than the nearby Ring-billed Gulls. When in flight, the bird had a very buoyant flight with quick wing beats which seemed different enough from Ring-billed Gulls as to identify the kittiwake in flight at all times, even when swirling with groups of Ring-billeds. Specific morphological and plumage characteristics noted are described below.

Head: The head was noticeably round and large, quite unlike the more angular profile of nearby Ring-billed Gulls. The bill was short and straight and was approximately one-third the length from the bill tip to the back of the head. The culmen was quite sloped and no gonydeal angle was observed. Overall head coloration was a smudgy gray save for a blackish ear spot that extended from the hindcrown ventrally to the cheek and rearward toward the anterior portion of the hindneck. The forehead, lores, cheeks, throat, and auriculars (except for the ear spot) were whiter than the remainder of the grayer head. The eye was dark.

Underparts: The throat, breast, belly, and vent were brightish white.

Upperparts: The mantle was mostly a deep gray, seemingly a shade darker than that of Ring-billed Gulls and the rump was white. The wings were also the same shade of deep gray except for the dark black primary tips with very small white mirrors observed to folded Primaries (P) 8-6. In flight, the outer wings were relatively narrow and swept back slightly which, with imagination, was more swallow-like than that of the nearby Ring-billed Gulls. When in flight, the basal gray coloration of the primaries was a slightly lighter shade than that of the mantle. The black primary tips were of the obvious "dipped in ink" pattern displaying an almost perpendicular shape from a distance roughly one-third that of between the tip of P10 and the greater primary coverts and P6. A dark leading edge was variably apparent on P10 when in flight. Though the majority of the secondaries were a deep gray, the trailing edge was white. Underwings appeared whitish (except for the black primary tips) but seemed to be grayer in the axillarie and inner coverts.

Tail: The tail was white and seemed slightly forked when banking in flight. When not banking, the tail appeared quite straight across the rectrice tips.

Legs and Feet: Noticeably black when perched or in flight.

Describe bird's call or song: None heard

Discuss similar species and how you eliminated them:

Ring-billed Gull: Ring-billed Gull is most similar in size and shape (though is longer-winged). The bill structure of a Ring-billed is different being somewhat longer, possessing a slight gonydeal angle, and lacking the more decurved culmen as a Kittiwake. The mantle color of a Ring-bill is slightly lighter gray overall. Ring-bills in winter plumage have some brownish streaking on the rear of the head and nape. Ring-bills also have a light yellow eye (not dark) and lack the gray ear smudge of a Kittiwake. Ring-bills will have white mirrors to the outer primaries and will have yellow (not black) legs.

Mew Gull: Mew Gulls also differ in shape, being more dove-like in appearance. Adult Mew Gulls in winter will have extensive brownish smudging to the nape, will have yellow (not black) legs, and will show white mirrors in the black primary tips.

Bonaparte's Gull: Bonaparte's would be much smaller, would have a lighter gray mantle, would have a very thin, all-black bill, would have pink legs, and would not have the "dipped in ink" pattern to the outer wings (would show extensive white flashes instead).

Black-headed Gull: Black-headed Gulls would be slightly smaller, would show two dark bars on the head (or one large ear spot), would have a dark red, thin bill, would have reddish legs (not black), would be slightly lighter mantled, and would also show extensive white flashes to the outer wings.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly appearing species? Observed another vagrant previously in Texas. Also observed on the East Coast and in Europe.

List books, guides, recordings or other sources consulted and how this influenced your identification (during and after observation): None

This report is from notes made during or after XX observation or later from memory

Date of written report: 12/24/00

Reporting observer: Larry Semo

Signature:



Reporting Observer's Address: 9054 Dover Street

City: Westminster

State: Colorado

Zip: 80021

Send report to:
Colorado Birds Record Committee
c/o Bill Lisowsky
2919 Silverplume Dr.
Ft. Collins, Co. 80526



Black-legged
Kittiwake
© Chatfield
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